// NO BIAS · NO SPONSORS

10 FITNESS PRODUCTS INVESTIGATED. WHICH ONES ACTUALLY WORK?

The research, my honest verdict and exactly what to use instead, so you get results faster. Every product gets the same four checks:

- → **The claim:** what the label promises you
- → **The research:** what the studies actually show
- → **The verdict:** worth it, situational or a waste of money
- → **The swap:** the cheaper thing that does the same job

THE FAD FREE GUIDE
BOON FAY

FREE PDF

// WHY I MADE THIS

I WAS ONE OF THE PEOPLE BEING SOLD TO.

I get it, because I was that guy. I took electrolytes every single day. I told guys at the gym they were idiots for only drinking water.

Then I actually started reading the research behind the stuff I was buying. A lot of it didn't hold up. Some of it said the exact opposite of the marketing.

So I made this. It's the 10 products I'd warn a friend about first, plus the ones I'd tell him are actually worth it. Every page works the same way, so you can make up your own mind. **Boon**

MY RULES

NO SPONSORS

Nobody paid to be in here, and nobody paid to stay out. If that ever changes, you'll hear it from me.

RESEARCH FIRST

Every verdict comes from what the studies show, not what the label says. Sources are on every page.

HONEST ABOUT DOUBT

When the evidence is weak or mixed, I'll tell you straight instead of pretending it's settled.

CHEAPEST THING THAT WORKS

If something cheaper does the same job, that's the swap. Spending more doesn't mean getting more.

// INSIDE THIS GUIDE

THE 10 PRODUCTS

Ranked from the stuff almost everyone buys to the more niche. Each page gives you the claim, the research, my verdict, the swap and what you could save.

01	HIGH-PROTEIN SNACKS	– SITUATIONAL
02	ELECTROLYTE PACKETS	– SITUATIONAL
03	PRE-WORKOUT	– SITUATIONAL
04	OZEMPIC	– SITUATIONAL
05	CREATINE	✓ WORTH IT
06	GREENS POWDERS	× WASTE OF MONEY
07	FAT BURNERS & GADGETS	× WASTE OF MONEY
08	TESTOSTERONE BOOSTERS	× WASTE OF MONEY
09	SWEAT BELTS & WAIST TRAINERS	× WASTE OF MONEY
10	COLD PLUNGE TUBS	– SITUATIONAL

✓ WORTH IT	Good evidence, fair price
– SITUATIONAL	Helps in specific cases
× WASTE OF MONEY	Weak evidence or a cheaper swap

PRODUCT 01 / 10 / LABELS

HIGH-PROTEIN SNACKS

Put the word protein on a box and people will pay double. Here's how loose the rules really are.



VERDICT **SITUATIONAL**

PRODUCT 01 / 10 / LABELS

– SITUATIONAL

HIGH-PROTEIN SNACKS

Put the word protein on a box and people will pay double. Here's how loose the rules really are.

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	TYPICAL COST
SITUATIONAL	Protein is real. A lot of the labels aren't.	Varies by product

THE CLAIM

The protein version is the healthier upgrade.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In the US, protein labels are measured against a 50g daily value. So a snack with just 5g can call itself a "good source," and 10g gets to say "high protein." Meanwhile, most guys who lift are aiming for 100g or more a day. Words like "protein packed" don't have a legal definition at all. Cheerios Protein got sued over its sugar in 2015, and Lenny & Larry's settled a class action over its protein claims without admitting wrongdoing.

THE SWAP

Use the calorie test. Take the calories and drop the last zero. If the protein grams beat that number, it's a solid pick.

MARKETING VS REALITY

✕ ~~Good source of protein~~	✓ **Could be just 5 grams**
✕ ~~Protein packed~~	✓ **Means nothing legally**
✕ ~~The protein upgrade~~	✓ **Sometimes just more sugar**

WHAT YOU SAVE **CHECK THE RATIO**

SOURCES: FDA nutrient content claim rules · Cheerios Protein lawsuit (2015) · Lenny & Larry's class action settlement

PRODUCT 02 / 10 / HYDRATION

ELECTROLYTE PACKETS

Made for cholera wards and football players passing out in the heat. Now they're sold as a daily habit.



VERDICT **SITUATIONAL**

PRODUCT 02 / 10 / HYDRATION

– SITUATIONAL

ELECTROLYTE PACKETS

Made for cholera wards and football players passing out in the heat. Now they're sold as a daily habit.

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	TYPICAL COST
SITUATIONAL	Strong for long, hot sessions. Weak for everyday use.	**~$47 a month (one Liquid I.V. stick a day)**

THE CLAIM

Water isn't enough. You need electrolytes every day.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

In 2012, the BMJ and Oxford dug into 431 sports drink claims. For one major brand, only 3 of 174 cited studies held up as high quality. Here's the part that surprised me: sweat is less salty than your blood, so a normal workout actually concentrates your sodium. The dangerous kind of low sodium mostly happens when people drink too much plain water during really long events.

THE SWAP

Plain water for normal training. Doing a long session in the heat? Add a pinch of salt and a splash of juice.

MARKETING VS REALITY

✕ ~~Prime: elite hydration~~
✓ **About 10mg of sodium**

✕ ~~871mg of electrolytes~~
✓ **Mostly potassium, 1mg over Liquid IV**

✕ ~~Water slows you down~~
✓ **California made Gatorade settle in 2017**

WHAT YOU SAVE **~$45/MO**

SOURCES: 2012 BMJ sports drinks investigation · Prime and Liquid IV labels · 2017 California Attorney General Gatorade settlement

PRODUCT 03 / 10 / PERFORMANCE

PRE-WORKOUT

The tingle, the pump, the "AI-powered peptides." The thing actually doing the work is caffeine.



VERDICT **SITUATIONAL**

PRODUCT 03 / 10 / PERFORMANCE

– SITUATIONAL

PRE-WORKOUT

The tingle, the pump, the "AI-powered peptides." The thing actually doing the work is caffeine.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL

EVIDENCE
Strong for caffeine. Mixed for most of the extras.

TYPICAL COST
~$35 per 30 scoops (C4 Original)

THE CLAIM
This blend gives you explosive energy and insane pumps every session.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Caffeine has the best evidence of anything in the tub, and C4 Original lists 200mg per scoop. That tingle you feel? It's beta-alanine, and it's a harmless side effect, not a sign it's working. Then there's the marketing stuff, like "AI-powered designer peptides." A lot of pre-workouts underdose everything else or hide it in a proprietary blend.

THE SWAP

Have a cup of coffee about 30 minutes before you train. If you like your pre-workout, just pick one with a fully disclosed label.

MARKETING VS REALITY

✕ ~~Explosive energy~~	✓ **Mostly caffeine**
✕ ~~The tingle means it works~~	✓ **It's just a side effect**
✕ ~~AI-powered peptides~~	✓ **Marketing, not muscle**

WHAT YOU SAVE **~$25+/MO**

SOURCES: C4 Original label · Caffeine and exercise performance research · Beta-alanine research

PRODUCT 04 / 10 / WEIGHT LOSS

OZEMPIC

The drug genuinely works. It's everything that popped up around it you need to watch out for.



VERDICT **SITUATIONAL**

PRODUCT 04 / 10 / WEIGHT LOSS

– SITUATIONAL

OZEMPIC

The drug genuinely works. It's everything that popped up around it you need to watch out for.

VERDICT	EVIDENCE	TYPICAL COST
SITUATIONAL	Strong, as a prescribed medication.	**~$1,000 list; $199 to $499 on cash programs**

THE CLAIM

Ozempic is a quick fix for anyone, and the natural versions work the same.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Semaglutide is the real deal: around 15% weight loss in clinical trials. But one large real-world study found closer to 4.5% after a year, and the weight often comes back once people stop. It's prescribed with slow dose increases, not as a quick cut. "Nature's Ozempic" supplements like berberine nudge the same fullness hormone, but nowhere near the drug. And no-prescription sellers have shipped contaminated or wrongly dosed products.

THE SWAP

If your weight is a real medical issue, talk to a doctor, including about the official cash-price programs. Skip the no-prescription sellers and the "natural" versions.

MARKETING VS REALITY

~~Quick fix for a few pounds~~	**Slow, supervised doses**
~~Nature's Ozempic~~	**Nowhere near the same effect**
~~No prescription needed~~	**No idea what's in it**

WHAT YOU SAVE **DOCTOR FIRST**

SOURCES: Semaglutide clinical trials · Real-world semaglutide outcomes study · Novo Nordisk pricing · FDA warnings on unapproved semaglutide

PRODUCT 05 / 10 / WORTH IT

CREATINE

One of the most researched supplements out there. Just don't pay extra for a fancy version.



VERDICT **WORTH IT**

PRODUCT 05 / 10 / WORTH IT

✓ WORTH IT

CREATINE

One of the most researched supplements out there. Just don't pay extra for a fancy version.

VERDICT
WORTH IT

EVIDENCE
Strong, for plain monohydrate.

TYPICAL COST
~$6 to $12 a month (plain monohydrate)

THE CLAIM
Fancy creatine absorbs better and works from the first dose.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Plain creatine monohydrate keeps showing up in the research for strength and muscle when you train. A 2008 study found creatine ethyl ester actually worked worse than plain monohydrate. Creatine also takes a few weeks to build up in your muscles, so "feel it on day one" isn't how it works. Some people naturally have high levels and notice less. Supplements aren't tested before they're sold, so pick one that's third-party tested.

THE SWAP

Plain, unflavored creatine monohydrate that's third-party tested. Honestly, that's the whole recommendation.

MARKETING VS REALITY

✗ ~~Advanced absorption~~
✓ **Monohydrate is the proven one**

✗ ~~Feel it on day one~~
✓ **Takes a few weeks**

✗ ~~Premium formula~~
✓ **The cheap one works best**

WHAT YOU SAVE **BEST VALUE**

SOURCES: 2008 creatine ethyl ester vs. monohydrate study · Creatine research reviews · Third-party testing programs

PRODUCT 06 / 10 / HEALTH

GREENS POWDERS

75 ingredients and a podcast host reading every ad. What you're mostly getting is an expensive multivitamin.



VERDICT **WASTE OF MONEY**

PRODUCT 06 / 10 / HEALTH

× WASTE OF MONEY

GREENS POWDERS

75 ingredients and a podcast host reading every ad. What you're mostly getting is an expensive multivitamin.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
Weak.

TYPICAL COST
$79 to $99 a month (AG1)

THE CLAIM
One scoop covers your nutrition and boosts energy, immunity and gut health.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Most greens powders use a proprietary blend, so you can't actually see if you're getting a useful dose of anything. And those huge amounts of vitamin C and biotin? Your body mostly pees out what it doesn't need. Put a popular greens powder next to a cheap multivitamin and it can come up short on minerals like calcium and magnesium. Public Health England even said greens powders don't count toward your five-a-day.

THE SWAP

Grab a bag of frozen vegetables. If your diet really has gaps, a basic multivitamin costs a fraction of the price.

MARKETING VS REALITY

~~75+ ingredients~~	**Doses hidden in a blend**
~~Better than a multivitamin~~	**Missing some key minerals**
~~Superfood blend~~	**"Superfood" means nothing**

WHAT YOU SAVE **~$70+/MO**

SOURCES: Product label vs. multivitamin label · Public Health England guidance (2018) · Company-funded study design

PRODUCT 07 / 10 / FAT LOSS

FAT BURNERS & GADGETS

Burning fat and losing fat aren't the same thing. This whole category depends on you not knowing that.



VERDICT **WASTE OF MONEY**

PRODUCT 07 / 10 / FAT LOSS

× WASTE OF MONEY

FAT BURNERS & GADGETS

Burning fat and losing fat aren't the same thing. This whole category depends on you not knowing that.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
Weak for actual fat loss.

TYPICAL COST
~$20 to $29 a month (Hydroxycut Hardcore)

THE CLAIM
Burn more fat with this pill, workout or device, and you'll lose more fat.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

"Burning fat" just means which fuel your body is using right now. You burn plenty of fat sitting on the couch. Your body balances fat and carbs over the whole day, and losing fat comes down to eating less energy than you burn over time. Hydroxycut Hardcore lists 265mg of caffeine per serving, and in the studies behind its key ingredient, both groups were on a low-calorie diet. The placebo group lost weight too.

THE SWAP

Stay in a consistent calorie deficit. Want the energy kick? The main ingredient in most fat burners is caffeine, and coffee is way cheaper.

MARKETING VS REALITY

- ✗ ~~Fat-burning zone~~
- ✓ **Not the same as fat loss**
- ✗ ~~Burn more fat~~
- ✓ **You'll store more later**
- ✗ ~~Thermogenic formula~~
- ✓ **Usually just caffeine**

WHAT YOU SAVE **~$20+/MO**

SOURCES: Hydroxycut Hardcore label and study claims · Fat oxidation and 24-hour energy balance research

PRODUCT 08 / 10 / HORMONES

TESTOSTERONE BOOSTERS

They're selling to one of the biggest insecurities guys have. Most of the ingredients don't deliver.



VERDICT **WASTE OF MONEY**

PRODUCT 08 / 10 / HORMONES

× WASTE OF MONEY

TESTOSTERONE BOOSTERS

They're selling to one of the biggest insecurities guys have. Most of the ingredients don't deliver.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
Weak for healthy men.

TYPICAL COST
~$65 to $70 a month (Nugenix Total-T)

THE CLAIM
Naturally boost your testosterone for more muscle, energy and drive.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

D-aspartic acid showed a short bump in one study, then levels were back to normal within weeks. Fenugreek and tribulus haven't raised testosterone in healthy men, and ashwagandha mostly helps guys who are already low. Tongkat ali has some evidence for a 10 to 20% increase, which might take you from 600 to about 700. Testosterone therapy roughly doubles levels. That's the gap between "statistically significant" and something you'd actually feel.

THE SWAP

Track your food for a week and fix real gaps like zinc, vitamin D and magnesium. Eat enough, sleep, lift. Got real symptoms? See a doctor.

MARKETING VS REALITY

× ~~Clinically proven~~
✓ **On paper, not in the mirror**

× ~~Boosts T naturally~~
✓ **Mostly if you're deficient**

× ~~Balances hormones~~
✓ **Which ones, and to what?**

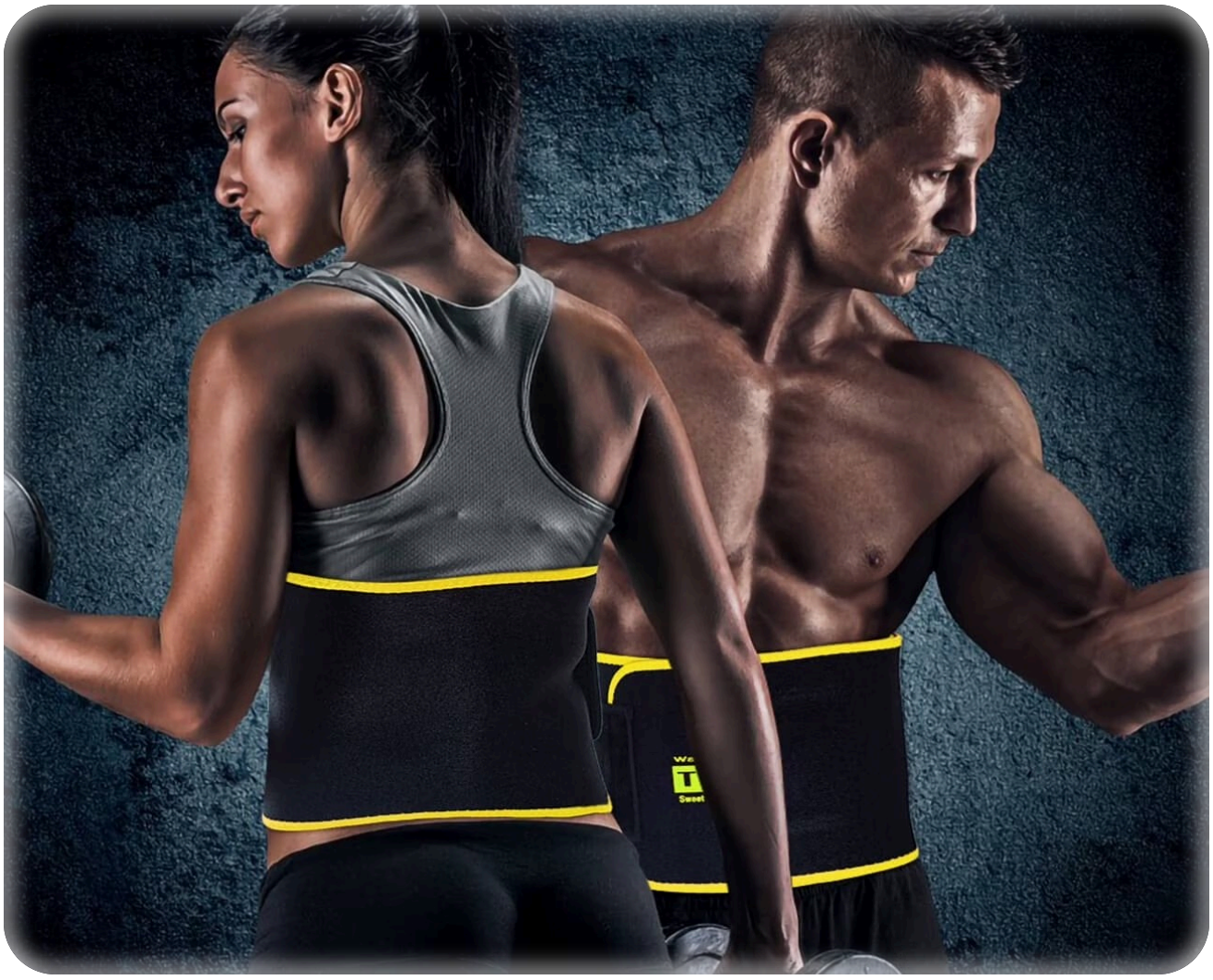
WHAT YOU SAVE **~$65/MO**

SOURCES: Tongkat ali meta-analysis · D-aspartic acid human studies · Examine.com ingredient summaries

PRODUCT 09 / 10 / GEAR

SWEAT BELTS & WAIST TRAINERS

Sweat more, lose inches. The only thing you're really losing is water.



VERDICT **WASTE OF MONEY**

PRODUCT 09 / 10 / GEAR

× WASTE OF MONEY

SWEAT BELTS & WAIST TRAINERS

Sweat more, lose inches. The only thing you're really losing is water.

VERDICT
WASTE OF MONEY

EVIDENCE
None for fat loss.

TYPICAL COST
~$22 to $40 per belt (Sweet Sweat), plus add-ons

THE CLAIM
Wear this belt while you train and you'll burn belly fat.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Sweating more doesn't burn more fat. It's water, and it comes right back the second you drink. You also can't melt fat from one spot by heating it up. Sweet Sweat's own listing says the belt helps cut excess water weight, and it's sold next to a sweat gel, a cleaning spray and arm and thigh trimmers. Even the instructions warn you not to wear it so tight it restricts your breathing.

THE SWAP

Skip it. Train, eat in a calorie deficit and drink your water. If you want support on heavy lifts, get a real lifting belt.

MARKETING VS REALITY

~~Burns belly fat~~	**Burns nothing extra**
~~Inches lost~~	**Water, back after you drink**
~~Sauna effect~~	**Just sweat**

WHAT YOU SAVE **~$30+**

SOURCES: Sweet Sweat product listing and instructions · Spot reduction research · Sweat and body water research

PRODUCT 10 / 10 / ✳ RECOVERY

COLD PLUNGE TUBS

A trend that can cost up to $8,000. And right after lifting, it might cost you some gains too.



VERDICT **SITUATIONAL**

PRODUCT 10 / 10 / ✳ RECOVERY

– SITUATIONAL

COLD PLUNGE TUBS

A trend that can cost up to $8,000. And right after lifting, it might cost you some gains too.

VERDICT
SITUATIONAL

EVIDENCE
Helps soreness. May blunt gains after lifting.

TYPICAL COST
~$1,150 (Ice Barrel) to ~$8,000 (Plunge)

THE CLAIM
A daily cold plunge speeds up recovery and helps you grow.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Cold water can help with soreness, and a lot of people love how it makes them feel. But some research suggests regular cold plunges right after strength training may blunt your long-term muscle and strength gains. Home setups run from about $1,150 for an ice barrel, plus the ice, up to around $8,000 for a tub with a built-in chiller.

THE SWAP

A cold shower costs nothing. If you do plunge, keep it away from your lifting sessions instead of right after.

MARKETING VS REALITY

✕ ~~Faster recovery~~
✓ **Less soreness, maybe fewer gains**

✕ ~~You need a tub~~
✓ **A cold shower works**

✕ ~~Plunge after every lift~~
✓ **Bad timing for muscle**

WHAT YOU SAVE **UP TO $8,000**

SOURCES: Cold water immersion and resistance training research · Ice Barrel and Plunge pricing

// PUT IT TO WORK

YOUR 7-DAY STARTER PLAN

Reading this is step one. Here's exactly what to do with it this week.

DAY 1 **AUDIT YOUR SHELF**
Write down every supplement and product you use, and what each one costs you a month.

DAY 2 **CUT THE RED ONES**
Stop anything this guide rated Waste of money. That's your first win, and it costs nothing.

DAY 3 **SET YOUR BASICS**
Pick a daily calorie target and a protein target of roughly 0.7 to 1 g per pound of bodyweight.

DAY 4 **ADD WHAT WORKS**
Start 3 to 5 g of plain creatine monohydrate a day. Same time, every day.

DAY 5 **FIX YOUR HYDRATION**
Water through the day. Save electrolytes for long, hot or extra sweaty sessions.

DAY 6 **TRAIN WITH A PLAN**
Three full-body sessions a week. Add a little weight or a rep each time.

DAY 7 **CHECK IN**
Weigh in, rate your energy and sleep, and keep what's working. Then repeat.

Do this for a week and you'll spend less, feel the difference and know exactly what's worth keeping.

// THANK YOU

Thanks for reading. I really hope this saves you some money and a lot of confusion. The point was never to make you paranoid about everything on the shelf. It's to help you spend on the stuff that actually works.

Boon

WANT THE FULL GUIDE?

This was just 10 products. My full guide, **Beyond the Label**, is a full investigation of 40+ fitness products, plus the exact system that got me results.

PART 1

THE TRENDS

TikTok physiques, the steroid wave, Ozempic and the fads everyone's talking about.

PART 2

EVERY SUPPLEMENT

40+ products rated worth it, situational or a waste of money, with the cheap swap for each.

PART 3

WHAT WORKED FOR ME

My own transformation, and the simple training, food and supplement system I actually use.

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OPINIONS, NOT GUARANTEES. Verdicts such as “Worth it,” “Situational” and “Waste of money” are the author’s personal opinions, based on publicly available research and product information at the time of writing. Research changes, products get reformulated and individual results vary. No outcome is promised or guaranteed.

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